

3 **MANMOHAN SINGH**

75, PRIME MINISTER (2)

BALANCING ACT

BECAUSE the economy has never looked better, with the country registering a GDP growth rate of 9 per cent for two years in a row and a four-year average of 8.6 per cent. Because he has lobbied at several international forums to end India's status as a nuclear pariah. Because he did not take the soft option of resigning when he did not get his way on the Indo-US nuclear deal. Because he has learnt to speak his mind.

TOUGH GUY TALK:

"So be it!"—when he told the Left they could withdraw support if they didn't like the nuclear deal.

BIG DISCOVERY: "In life, one has to live with some disappointments."

TIME OFF: Watched a Shah Rukh Khan movie on his Air India One flight from Beijing. But, as he

endearingly told the actor, he couldn't remember its name.

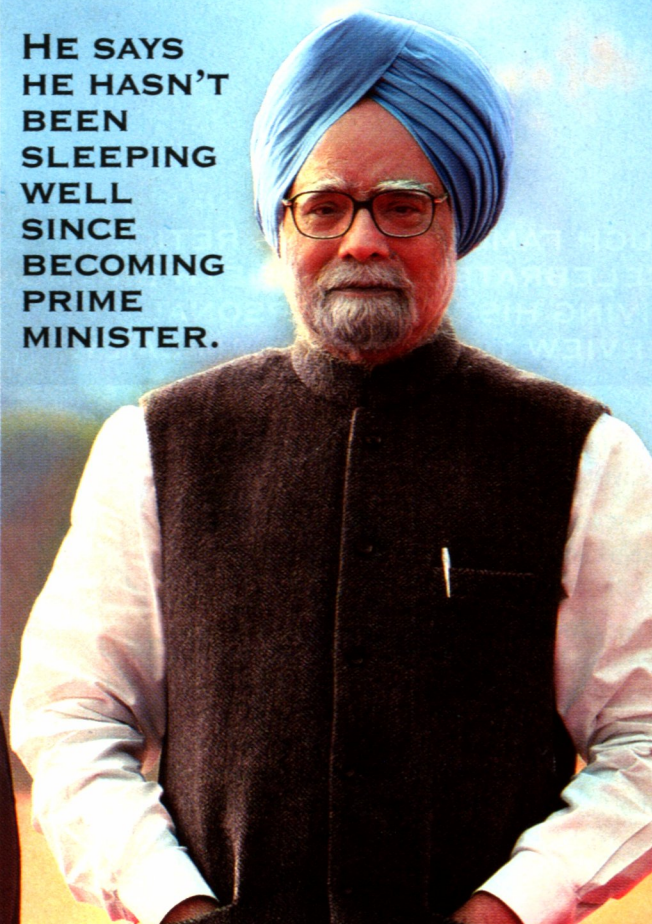
STRANGE BUT TRUE:

Is sheepish about his public speaking skills but retorts: "You can't teach an old dog new tricks."

SIGNATURE STYLE:

A grey turban for special occasions and a silver Cross pen.

HE SAYS HE HASN'T BEEN SLEEPING WELL SINCE BECOMING PRIME MINISTER.



HEMANT CHAWLA

MAYAWATI

52, CHIEF MINISTER, UTTAR PRADESH (NEW)

POLL VAULT

BECAUSE few doubt her when she says she will be prime minister one day. Because the three-time chief minister pulled off a historic win in Uttar Pradesh where BSP won an absolute majority, ending 15 years of coalition rule in the state. Because now her influence is growing beyond her state, not just to the north but also in parts of the south. Because when it is her birthday, every political suitor calls, including Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi.

SIGNATURE STYLE:

Wears pink when it matters, as at the victory press conference after the elections and at most of her birthday bashes.

PARTICULAR ABOUT:

Visitors at her home removing their shoes outside the drawing room.

COY MOVE: Changes her rubber slippers before posing for a photoshoot.

SHOULD BE EMBARRASSED ABOUT:

Saying "*mare hue ko kya maarna*" soon after winning and then proceeding to reverse every single decision Mulayam Singh had made.

DESPITE BEING A DALIT ICON, SHE HAS CROSSED THE CASTE BARRIER, WITH 34 OF THE 206 BSP MLAS BEING BRAHMINS.